print between those who supported such ‘big government’ plans as essential for the development of the United States and many who preferred a ‘small government’ approach and saw Adams’s plans as federal overreach and an encroachment on states’ rights.

Northern supporters of the ‘small government’ camp complained that it was unconstitutional for the federal government to tax the citizens of richer states in order to build roads in poorer states. Southerners feared that a federal government that claims the power to build a lighthouse of the skies in their backyard may one day claim the power to free their slaves, too. Adams was accused of harbouring dictatorial ambitions, while the erudition and sophistication of his speech were criticised as elitist and disconnected from ordinary Americans. The public debates over the 1825 message to Congress dealt a severe blow to the reputation of the Adams administration and helped pave the way to Adams’s subsequent electoral defeat. In the 1828 presidential elections, Adams lost to Andrew Jackson – a rich slave-holding planter from Tennessee who was successfully rebranded in numerous newspaper columns as ‘the man of the people’ and who claimed that the previous elections were in fact stolen by Adams and by the corrupt Washington elites.[46]

Newspapers of the time were of course still slow and limited compared with the mass media of today. Newspapers travelled at the pace of a horse or sailing boat, and relatively few people read them regularly. There were no newsstands or street vendors, so people had to buy subscriptions, which were expensive; average annual subscriptions cost around one week’s wages for a skilled journeyman. As a result, the total number of subscribers to all US newspapers in 1830 is estimated at just seventy-eight thousand. Since some subscribers were associations or businesses rather than individuals, and since every copy was probably read by several people, it seems reasonable to assume that regular newspaper readership numbered in the hundreds of thousands. But millions more people rarely, if ever, read newspapers.[47]

No wonder that American democracy in those days was a limited affair – and the domain of wealthy white men. In the 1824 elections that brought Adams to power, 1.3 million Americans were theoretically eligible to vote, out of an adult population of about 5 million (or around 25 per cent). Only 352,780 people – 7 per cent of the total adult population – actually made use of their right. Adams didn’t even win a majority of those who voted.